

Export Shipment Control Workbook

User Guide — Validation Edition

What This Is

This workbook helps you catch documentation mismatches — invoice, packing list, and Bill of Lading disagreeing on quantity, buyer name, weight, or other details — before you submit a shipment to customs.

Use it as an early cross-check to identify discrepancies that may require correction or further review before shipment processing.

This is a documentation cross-check aid, not a substitute for official CHA/customs clearance review. Verify all findings independently before shipment.

Who It's For

Export operations staff, Customs House Agents (CHAs), and small exporters who currently track shipment documentation in spreadsheets, email, or memory, and want a structured way to catch mismatches before they become customs problems.

The Five Sheets

The workbook has five tabs. Each shipment gets one row on each of the first three sheets, tied together by its Shipment ID.

1. Shipment_Master

The summary view. One row per shipment — buyer, invoice number, ports, dates, forwarder — plus a single “Overall Status” column (I) that tells you at a glance whether the shipment is ready, pending documents, or has issues.

Column I is a formula and is locked. Don't try to type into it — it calculates itself from the other four sheets. Use Column J for your own notes instead.

2. Doc_Checklist

Tracks whether each required document has been finalized: Commercial Invoice, Packing List, Draft B/L, Certificate of Origin, and Shipping Bill. Use the dropdown in each cell — typing free text that doesn't match an exact dropdown value will not be recognized as “done”.

3. Logistics_Log

Container, seal number, package count, and weights. This sheet automatically flags two things: Net Weight exceeding Gross Weight (a physical impossibility, always an error), and VGM differing from Gross Weight by more than 10kg (an internal tolerance, not a regulatory figure — see the cell comment on the VGM column for details).

4. Manual_Check

This is where you compare the same field — buyer name, quantity, container number, etc. — across the Invoice, Packing List, and Draft B/L side by side. If all three agree, it shows a green Match. If they disagree, you'll also see:

5. Exception_Log

The permanent record of issues found and their resolution status (Open, Pending Revision, Closed). This is the one sheet that directly controls Overall Status: if a shipment has an open Critical exception logged here, its Overall Status will show “Audit - Issues Found” — even if every other sheet looks perfectly clean.

- Document Pair (auto) — which two documents actually disagree

- Exception Description (auto) — the three values written out, ready to copy
- Suggested Severity (auto) — based on the Risk Level you set
- Action Needed — tells you to log it in Exception_Log if it's a real mismatch

Important: entering a mismatch here does not automatically create an Exception_Log entry. You still need to copy it over yourself — see the next section for why.

How Overall Status Actually Works

Shipment_Master checks things in this order, and stops at the first problem it finds:

1. Is there an open, Critical exception logged for this shipment? → Audit - Issues Found
2. Does Logistics_Log show a weight error? → Audit - Issues Found
3. Does Manual_Check show an unresolved Mismatch for this shipment? → Audit - Issues Found
4. Are all five documents in Doc_Checklist complete? → Ready for Audit
5. Otherwise → Documents Pending

Manual_Check and Exception_Log are two separate systems. A mismatch you spot in Manual_Check is a visual flag for you — it does not write itself into Exception_Log. Treat Exception_Log as the source of truth, and Manual_Check as your workspace for finding problems before you log them.

Quick Start — Adding a New Shipment

- Go to the first empty row (below the existing data) on Shipment_Master and fill in the shipment details.
- Use the same Shipment ID on Doc_Checklist and Logistics_Log, in their own next empty rows.
- Fill in Doc_Checklist using the dropdowns only — exact matches required.
- If you want to manually cross-check documents, add rows to Manual_Check with the same Shipment ID, one row per field you're comparing.
- If Manual_Check flags a real mismatch, copy the auto-generated Document Pair, Description, and Severity into a new row in Exception_Log, along with an Action Owner and Resolution Status.
- Check Shipment_Master column I — it updates automatically.

Common Mistakes

- Typing a value that isn't an exact dropdown match (e.g. "Received" where the sheet expects "Final") — the formula won't recognize it, and Overall Status will show Documents Pending even though you filled the cell.
- Retagging an existing row's Shipment ID without updating the data in it — this silently attaches the old row's findings to the new shipment. Only add new shipments in fresh, empty rows.
- Expecting Exception_Log to fill itself in — it doesn't. Manual_Check only prepares the text; a person still has to log it.

Questions or Issues

This is a validation build — if something doesn't behave as described here, or you'd like a free shipment audit on your own documents, reach out:

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